security man, for permission to run in a nearby park as Belly, who had found his form, led us to an eight-wicket win.

Suddenly, it was the Aussies' turn to be put in the stocks. Lehmann was forced to deny he had angered his players, and broken the spirit of their 'family first' policy, by not recalling Haddin after he missed the Lord's Test to be with his daughter Mia in a London hospital. Michael Clarke's captaincy was being picked apart. Batting coach Michael Di Venuto was urging the team to toughen up.

My priorities were revealingly different. 'Lads, we're in a situation probably no one thought we'd be in,' I told the team, in what was a messy dressing room. 'Don't go and finish yourself tonight. By all means enjoy the win, but please, please, please, don't go and get blind drunk.' Once they dispersed, I phoned Stokes, put him in charge of the night, and told him to decide when they had had enough.

He got them back to the hotel by midnight. They were on a promise. Win the Ashes by pressing home our advantage at Trent Bridge and I wouldn't care if they turned up legless at the Oval. As things turned out, the performance in Nottingham was 100 per cent proof. To be batting before lunch on the first day, after bowling Australia out for 60 on winning the toss, was intoxicating.

Stuart Broad's spell of 8–15 in nine and a half overs that morning was the most impactful I've ever seen. There's usually one partnership, to stem the bleeding. I don't think even he could believe it, especially since it's now safe to reveal that he wanted me to bat first. To do it on his home ground, knowing he shouldered primary responsibility in Jimmy's absence, was the mark of the man. No one delivers every day, but the best choose their moments.

The atmosphere in the changing room during the interval was dreamlike. Adam Lyth hit the last ball of the morning session for four, and no one seemed remotely interested in eating. It had the feel of Melbourne 2010, a sense of disbelief, tempered by the unspoken knowledge that if we batted properly, the Ashes would be ours.

Play long enough, and there is always something to bring you down to earth. I remembered, with a pang of regret and alarm, being in an Essex side that once lost to Yorkshire, after bowling them out for 50 in the first innings. Rooty, unbeaten on 124 at the end of a surreal first day, provided